

4.9

Photography and videography

Kingston University is a serious and ambitious university.

Brands are about being unique and distinctive. The University should avoid using stock imagery and instead should commission original content.

Great photography communicates quickly and can overcome the need for text. A single great image may communicate more effectively than any number of words. It is therefore more effective and efficient to commission fewer images of the highest possible quality.

Photography and videography should be commissioned from reliable professional sources and supported by experienced creative direction and detailed briefing. It is reasonable to expect to invest in an amount of post-production digital retouching, to remove blemishes such as graffiti or debris.

Videography should be commissioned from an experienced documentary film maker and not from a stills photographer.

Hand-held images taken by amateurs should be avoided, not least because the University has a reputation for producing high quality art school educated graduates. In order to compete and win at the highest level the University should behave professionally and have the highest standards. From an external perspective, the University's outputs are judged against those of other professional organisations and should stand up to comparison with them.

Students should not be expected to produce work of the same quality as experienced professionals.

Photography and videography should communicate the University's desired 'future state' including its Values and evidence showing that it is the 'UK's leading university for Future Skills'.

Photography and videography should be from a 'fly on the wall' perspective, looking in on the action and drama in a style that could be called 'reportage'.

Images should aim to:

- demonstrate 'Future Skills in action' in Kingston University (digital, collaborative, innovative and creative problem solving)
- embody the University's values: Ambitious, Inclusive, Enterprising and Innovative
- be dynamic and active and lead the viewer into the action that is the focus of the shot
- reflect the focus and content of the copy and or the brief
- perform as a set so items are homogenous
- reflect the diversity of the student and staff population
- demonstrate what 'inclusion' looks (and feels) like, including gender balance and age
- focus on those that are most candid and authentic (and NOT posed or staring down the lens)
- evidence the diversity of learning opportunities
- have the focus of the shot towards to top half-centre of the frame to allow for cropping and application of text
- be in a variety of formats—portrait and landscape
- please note that photography / video content for use on websites should be shot in landscape or panoramic view
- avoid or remove litter, bins, graffiti, boring ceilings and floors
- have carefully considered backgrounds, props and backdrops

Section 4.9 - Photography and videography

Brand Guidance
V.1 March 2025

All photography and videography should be attributed and the University should be careful to obtain the rights to use commissioned images **for their stated purpose and for a stated duration**. Using images in ways not stated in the terms of the contract is a breach of contract and may be illegal. Never use moving or still images without the permission of the originator.

The Corporate Communications team has a list of professional photographers and videographers.

Email

corporatecommunications@kingston.ac.uk

If you need to access a permission form or see a sample contract.

4.9.1

Commissioning architectural photography

Always engage a photographer who specialises in architecture and building interiors.

In order to properly photograph architecture and building interiors specialist lighting and lenses may be required, including to ensuring verticals and horizontals are parallel.

Photographs may be used ONLY for the purpose for which they are commissioned, solely for use by the University unless otherwise agreed. Photographs MUST be credited as agreed by the University and the photographer. The University is wholly responsible for controlling the use and distribution of its commissioned photography and will be liable for any misuse. This applies to photography appearing in both print and online.

Prepare a checklist prior to your discussions with photographers.

Some of the information included in your checklist may be included as part of the contract between both parties.

Arrange access to the location including parking and security clearance and, if required, permission from neighbouring properties. Ensure the relevant areas are accessible and that the photographer has contact information for the location manager and that they have been briefed and any pre-arrangements undertaken prior to the photoshoot.

The client is responsible for the tidiness and appearance of the location to be photographed. Be aware that removing signage, obstacles, rubbish and graffiti digitally may be impossible or expensive. In order to give you an accurate quotation for the work the photographer will require the following information:

About your needs

- Consider the number of images you need
- Consider the format of the images – are they portrait or landscape?
- Consider the file formats and resolution required for the final application of the images
- If images are to be cropped, or have text over them, describe the proportions of the shots required
- Share any style guidance and examples with the photographer
- Be clear about the purpose of the images – if they are a record of a completed project, or if they have a promotional purpose
- Do you plan to share photos with a third party? If so, for what purpose? – this is vitally important to ensure you agree relevant permissions from the photographer
- Be very clear about your deadlines including when and how the location can be accessed and when you need delivery of the photographs

About the location

- Obtain the precise address and location of the site – this will allow the photographer to ascertain parking and unloading restrictions and any obstacles that may inhibit, assess to light or sunlight
- A site reconnaissance may be required and a time and cost allowance included for this
- Do you need props, including furniture, for interior shots?
- Consider implications of branded clothing to avoid extensive retouching after the shoot
- Consider work patterns and plan the shoot to avoid fire alarms, changes of shift workers, lunchtimes etc

Photography guidance

- Is it a secure site?
- Is it an industrial site?
- Is there public access and / or children in the area – ensure you obtain the necessary permissions
- If people are to be included consider inclusion, diversity guidance and advice on suitable clothing for the shoot
- Is the site subject to particular Health and Safety requirements?
- How many buildings are to be photographed?
- Do you require internal or external images or both?
- Are there particular features to be photographed, such as entrances?
- Are landscaping, paths and roads to be included?
- Do you want daytime or evening shots?
- Do you want to show a particular season?
– consider bare trees, brown grass, reflections on wet pavements and rain on glass
- Do you want movement to be expressed, such as by a long exposure of people moving through a space, or are the shots devoid of people?
- Consider the weather – plan the year ahead and / or wait for clear skies that make for great daytime and evening shots